

Florida State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	A talented, bowl-plus team with a settled quarterback, an elite receiving anchor and a 2025 offensive efficiency base worth respecting, but whose range remains wide because every principal 2025 OL starter is gone and the defense leans heavily on new transfer pieces.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · ACC media 11th (1,439 points; 3 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 35
Returning production	57% (No. 50) overall · Off. 57% (No. 58) · Def. 57% (No. 50)
Primer power rating	+9.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.6 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar overall with a better chance to convert efficiency into wins, but more line-of-scrimmage variance
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Mike Norvell resumes offensive play-calling with QB Ashton Daniels settled at quarterback, WR Duce Robinson as the proven receiving star and RB Ousmane Kromah/RB Quintrevion Wisner forming the projected backfield. The tension is up front: all five principal 2025 OL starters are gone. Tony White retains defensive system leadership while a mix of returners and transfers rebuilds the front and secondary.

Bottom line: Florida State's 2025 underlying offense was much better than the 5-7 record, so the No.35/+9.0 projection is credible, but an entirely new principal OL and substantial defensive turnover make 7-5 a midpoint rather than a secure floor on a 7/10 schedule.

Beats expectations if: Daniels' experience, Robinson's explosiveness and the Kromah/Wisner backfield let Norvell preserve the 2025 offense's top-30 efficiency while the transfer-built OL coheres quickly and White gets immediate starter-level play from the defensive additions.

Disappoints if: The new OL cannot replace the veteran 2025 group, the offense's explosive-play advantage disappears under protection/run-blocking stress, and the defensive newcomers fail to improve a unit that ranked No.68 in EPA allowed and No.84 in havoc created.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB / play-calling stability:** QB Ashton Daniels is the settled QB1 and Mike Norvell is the 2026 offensive play-caller; Tim Harris Jr. remains OC/WR and system collaborator.
- 2 ★ WR Duce Robinson:** WR Duce Robinson returns after 56 catches for 1,081 yards and six touchdowns and carries AP second-team, ACC first-team and major national-award recognition.
- 3 ? OL rebuild:** Every principal 2025 OL starter is gone; the projected new five is taking shape, but right-side deployment and reserve order remain unsettled.
- 4 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense was legitimately strong beneath the 5-7 record: total offense No.6, rush offense No.11, third downs No.8, adjusted offense No.27 and explosive-play rate No.6; the defense prevented explosives well (No.25) but created havoc at only No.84.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No.34 (7/10), with Alabama, Miami, Clemson, Louisville and Florida among the high-end tests; two byes help separate the schedule into manageable preparation blocks.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-7 (2-6 ACC)	● Poor
Scoring	33.0 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	472.1 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	218.7 YPG · 5.2 YPC	● Elite
Pass efficiency	8.97 YPA · 20 TD / 9 INT	● Very good
Third downs	50.9%	● Elite
Scoring defense	22.0 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	328.8 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	138.1 YPG · 3.6 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	190.8 YPG · 7.02 YPA · 20 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Florida State's 5-7 record badly understated an offense that moved the ball and converted third downs at an elite level. The defense was respectable overall, but less convincing against the run and by passing efficiency.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.60 · No. 27	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.095 · No. 31	● Very good
Off. success rate	47.0% · No. 27	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	15.9% · No. 6	● Elite
Havoc allowed	13.6% · No. 43	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+1.44 · No. 52	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.009 · No. 68	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	41.2% · No. 65	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.0% · No. 25	● Very good
Havoc created	14.7% · No. 84	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Florida State’s 2025 offense was far more convincing than the final record: top 31 in adjusted offense, EPA and success, No.6 in explosive rate, plus top-11 traditional total/rush production. The defense was middle-of-the-pack in efficiency but good at preventing explosives.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Mike Norvell - returning / resumes play-calling	● ↔ Norvell’s return to play-calling removes ambiguity and puts the offense directly back under his control.
OC / WR	◆ Tim Harris Jr. - promoted internally; from Florida State Co-Offensive Coordinator/Wide Receivers Coach	● ↔ The internal promotion preserves terminology and receiver continuity while changing coordinator responsibility.
DC	Tony White - returning	● ↔ White’s return keeps the defensive system stable while the personnel around it changes.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Quintrevion Wisner	Texas	● ↑ Projects into the top backfield rotation with Kromah and adds proven Power 4 ability.
◆ OL Xavier Chaplin	Auburn	● ↔ Looks set for left tackle in an entirely rebuilt principal OL.
◆ OL Bradyn Welch-Joiner	Purdue	● ↑ Brings 17 prior starts and is projected at center, making him the most experienced stabilizer in the new five.
◆ OL Chimdia Nwaiwu	Stephen F. Austin	● ↔ Figures into the right-tackle picture but remains part of unresolved right-side deployment.

Out	To	Loss
QB Tommy Castellanos	Rookie-minicamp opportunity (Titans and Dolphins)	● ↔ The 12-game 2025 starter departs, but Daniels is already settled as the replacement QB1.
OL Micah Pettus	Undrafted; Kansas City NFL opportunity	● ↓ Eleven starts at right tackle are part of the complete principal-OL reset.
OL Gunnar Hansen	Rookie-minicamp opportunity (New York Jets)	● ↓ Twelve starts at left tackle remove another veteran edge protector.
OL Luke Petitbon	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ A 12-start first-team All-ACC center is a major continuity/quality loss.
OL Richie Leonard IV	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Eleven starts and All-ACC honorable mention status leave a material guard vacancy.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Similar ceiling with more line risk: settled QB/WR/RB skill can preserve a strong offense, but replacing all five principal OL starters is the most important negative composition change on the roster.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL/Edge Rylan Kennedy	Texas A&M	● ↔ Part of a transfer-heavy front rebuild with a projected major role.
◆ DL/Edge Chris Jones	Southern Miss	● ↔ Adds experienced front depth to replace major departures.
◆ LB Mikai Gbayer	North Carolina	● ↔ Projected into a linebacker group replacing LB Justin Cryer and other 2025 contributors.
◆ DB Ma'Khi Jones	Duke	● ↔ Provides competition to a secondary replacing Jerry Wilson and other departures.

Out	To	Loss
DL Darrell Jackson Jr.	NFL (N.Y. Jets), Round 4, No. 103	● ↓ A starting interior defender and captain-level contributor is a clear front-line loss.
CB Jeremiah (Jerry) Wilson	NFL (Los Angeles Chargers), UDFA	● ↓ Twelve starts and All-ACC honorable mention production leave the secondary without a proven full-season corner anchor opposite Rawls.
S Earl Little Jr.	Ohio State	● ↔ Material safety experience exits an already reordered secondary.
LB Justin Cryer	Texas	● ↔ Removes meaningful linebacker experience and increases newcomer dependence.
S Edwin Joseph	Ole Miss	● ↔ Adds to the back-end turnover that makes secondary ordering an open question.

Defensive net: ● ↔ Worse on proven continuity, with enough transfer talent to remain functional but not enough settled evidence to call the rebuilt group an upgrade.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Mike Norvell offense built around QB Ashton Daniels, WR Duce Robinson and the RB Ousmane Kromah/RB Quintrevion Wisner backfield	Settled QB1 and a high-end receiving anchor support the efficiency base	A fully rebuilt principal OL creates major protection and continuity risk
Defense	Tony White scheme continuity with a transfer-heavy personnel reset	CB Ja’Bril Rawls and DL Daniel Lyons provide returning anchors	New front-seven and secondary pieces must replace substantial 2025 experience
Special teams	Transfer-led specialist reset	K Gabe Panikowski and P Daniel Hughes bring preseason recognition	Primary long-snapper continuity changes with the broader operation

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↔	High	QB Ashton Daniels is settled with extensive prior starting experience.
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Ousmane Kromah and RB Quintrevion Wisner form a proven top rotation.
WR	● B+	● ↓	Medium	WR Duce Robinson is an elite anchor, but departures leave less proven depth behind him.
TE	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	The shared-role competition remains unsettled without a single established starter.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	All five principal 2025 starters are gone; the new five has no shared starting continuity.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↓	Medium	DL Daniel Lyons returns, but major departures force transfers into immediate roles.
LB	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Transfer additions can offset losses, but newcomer dependence limits confidence.
Secondary	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Ja’Bril Rawls anchors a back end replacing a starting corner and multiple safeties.
Special teams	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	K Gabe Panikowski and P Daniel Hughes bring recognition, but the operation changes.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	High	Mike Norvell resumes play-calling and DC Tony White remains, preserving system leadership.
Overall	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	QB certainty and strong 2025 offensive efficiency support +9.0, while OL and defensive newcomer dependence cap confidence.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Duce Robinson	WR	● High-end national receiver / offensive star	Associated Press second team · ACC First Team · Biletnikoff · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	His 56-1,081-6 2025 line gives FSU a proven explosive centerpiece while the OL is rebuilt.
◆ Ashton Daniels (TR: Auburn)	QB	● Solid experienced Power 4 starter	-	Settled QB1 status sharply lowers offensive uncertainty compared with the rest of the roster rebuild.
Ousmane Kromah	RB	● High-upside lead-rotation back	Doak Walker	Pairs with Wisner to give Norvell a credible backfield while the line finds cohesion.
◆ Quintrevion Wisner (TR: Texas)	RB	● Proven Power 4 rotation/lead-back candidate	-	Incoming transfer supplies another experienced option and reduces dependence on a single back.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Bradyn Welch-Joiner (TR: Purdue)	C	● Experienced OL stabilizer	-	Seventeen prior starts and a projected center role make him the most important cohesion piece in the all-new principal five.
Ja’Bril Rawls	CB	● Proven starting corner / defensive anchor	Bednarik	Started seven games with 40 tackles and an interception before injury; current-roster return gives the secondary its clearest known anchor.
Daniel Lyons	DL	● Experienced interior anchor	-	One of the most important same-school continuity pieces in a transfer-heavy defensive front.
◆ Gabe Panikowski (TR: Oklahoma State)	K	● Recognized specialist	Lou Groza	Incoming kicker can stabilize scoring opportunities even as the overall specialist operation changes.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Difficult for a 7-5 baseline; two byes help, but the top-end opponents leave little room for OL growing pains.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 34
Hardest stretch	Virginia → at Louisville → at Miami → bye → Clemson
Swing games	SMU, Virginia, at Louisville, Clemson, at Pittsburgh, Florida
Advantage	Two byes break up the schedule, and New Mexico State/Central Arkansas provide home nonconference opportunities around the Alabama trip.
Expected	6.6 wins · most likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	FSU is attractive when the market anchors too heavily to 5-7 and discounts the quality of the 2025 offense, but the all-new OL makes it dangerous to pay a premium before protection/run-blocking cohesion is demonstrated.
Back them when	QB Ashton Daniels and WR Duce Robinson have a passing edge and the opponent cannot overwhelm the rebuilt OL.
Fade/pass when	Against elite defensive fronts or teams capable of forcing long-yardage situations and making the new OL win repeated obvious-pass downs; also pass when secondary ordering/availability is unclear without enough price edge.
Key monitor	final OL five/right-side ordering, TE split, secondary order beyond CB Ja’Bril Rawls, defensive-front rotation, late availability
Week 1 baseline	rating-only fair baseline Florida State –29.5 ; Florida State primer +9.0 minus New Mexico State final preseason SP+ proxy -18.5 plus 2.0 default home field; no matchup or availability adjustment Live market: Florida State –30.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Florida State has a credible rebound case because QB Ashton Daniels is settled, WR Duce Robinson is a proven star and the 2025 offense was far better than the 5-7 record suggests. Mike Norvell’s return to play-calling adds another stable offensive lever.

The range stays wide because every principal 2025 OL starter is gone and the defense is transfer-heavy. Seven wins is a reasonable midpoint, with upside if the new line coheres quickly and the defensive additions settle into major roles.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [2025 context](#) · [current update](#)

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